The UN has been warned repeatedly as to how bad the situation is[19] and indeed it has continued to publish highly critical reports.[20] But, as ever, its impact is limited, in part by the enduring politics of the Security Council (in this case it is most likely that China and Russia would back the Myanmar military), and also by the fact that it has multiple roles in Myanmar. Some observers were afraid that the UN's criticism of the conduct of the census was muted due to fear that its other humanitarian efforts would be evicted from Rakhine[21]—as happened to MSF recently.[22] However, consistent pressure matters and while criticism annoys the Myanmar authorities[23] it is clear that they do take some steps to avoid overt criticism.

The US, and to a much lesser extent the EU, are important influences. Both have been generally tolerant of the regime[24] (especially the EU), and both seem to hope that in some way the military are allies of the move towards democracy,[25] which they seem to think will alleviate the situation of the Rohingyas. So far, the Western powers have sometimes scolded,[26] sometimes chided[27] Myanmar but the pressure is inconsistent. Both the US and their allies have found it easier to talk about relaxing sanctions so as to reward progress[28]—to the extent that the only sanctions the EU retains are related to direct arms sales—rather than consider just what progress has actually occurred. But simply ignoring the plight of the Rohingyas and emphasising trade links is a deeply flawed approach. If, or perhaps more accurately when, Rakhine descends into extreme violence, many firms that have invested substantively will be deeply embarrassed and may well lose their new assets.[29] Economic progress is not an alternative to human rights; it fundamentally depends on the acceptance of human rights.

China is often presented as being indifferent to the governance of the states where it invests and where it has, in its terms, strategic interests. It seems that it prefers authoritarian partners[30] and that it can be ruthless in its pursuit of its self-interests.[31] But it is also a pragmatic regime. It has recently started a dialogue with the NLD,[32] presumably in the expectation that the latter will take a role in the government after the 2015 elections. It is unlikely that China would pressure Myanmar over the wider issue of democratic reforms, but it might be less tolerant if unrest in Rakhine threatened its vital infrastructure projects.